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The Way Forward

AT THE time of writing this, forty-two years have passed since Operation Bhindranwale-Khalistan (Op-1) was conceived in 1978 by Sanjay Gandhi with the blessings of Indira Gandhi, and forty since its scope was upgraded from a state-level to a national-level operation (Op-2), with the sole purpose of winning elections due by January 1985 for the Congress. Unfortunately, India continues to grapple with the forces set in motion by the misadventure of a couple of power-wielding young men and their friends, all extra-constitutional entities.

The religious divide of gigantic proportions created over a period finally led to an ill-conceived, badly planned and horribly executed Operation Blue Star, and to a carefully planned and surgically executed pogrom against Sikhs that followed the assassination of Indira Gandhi in Delhi and some other cities of India. In Punjab, the anguish this generated amongst the Sikh youth resulted in the most dreadful decade the state had seen. Thousands of angry young Sikhs took to militancy, lost their lives – some accounted for, but many more still missing – before peace returned to this land.

While Sikhs were awaiting justice for the horrendous crimes of November 1984 and what happened in Punjab before, during and after Operation Blue Star, other than some window-dressing in the form of the appointment of thirteen commissions, committees and SITs (see Annexure II), nobody really attempted to unravel and address the actual issues involved, as if the appointment of mere commissions and committees were good enough to settle the matter. For good measure, what happened in Punjab during the fifteen-year